

Parachurch Ministries

doc-parachurch-ministries

Inter-church Relations · Parachurch · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

INSUFFICIENT

Supported across many Bible texts

Subject covered by a category in Scripture

Holds across manuscript variants

Statement under examination

Parachurch ministries (mission agencies, campus ministries, mercy organisations, training institutions) are legitimate when they support and serve the local church rather than replace it.

In plain language

The Greek words behind these passages tell a consistent story about how the earliest Christian mission and relief work was organised. In Acts 13 the prophets and teachers, including Barnabas and Saul, are members of the assembly (ekklesia, ἐκκλησία, the local church) at Antioch. While the church is ministering or serving (leitourgounton, λειτουργούντων) and fasting (nesteuonton, νηστευόντων), the Holy Spirit tells them to 'set apart' (aphorise, ἀφορίσατε) Barnabas and Saul 'for the work' (eis to ergon, εἰς τὸ ἔργον) he is calling them to. The congregation then fasts, prays, lays hands on the two men (epithentes tas cheiras, ἐπιθέντες τὰς χεῖρας), and sends them off. In Acts 14 Paul and Barnabas return and 'appoint elders in every assembly' by hand-stretching (cheirotonesantes kat' ekklesian, χειροτονήσαντες κατ' ἐκκλησίαν), the same procedural verb later used for choosing delegates, fixing leadership inside each local body. In Romans 15 Paul carries a relief gift to the poor believers in Jerusalem. The churches of Macedonia and Achaia, he says, 'were glad to make a contribution or sharing' (koinonia, κοινωνία), and since the Gentiles 'shared' (ekoinonesan, ἐκοινώνησαν) in their spiritual blessings, they owe it to 'render service' (leitourgesai, λειτουργῆσαι) to them in material things. He calls the collection a 'fruit' (karpos, καρπός) he will deliver and seal. The clearest organisational pattern shows up in 2 Corinthians 8. The brother sent with Titus is described as 'chosen by hand-stretching by the churches' (cheirotoneis hypo ton ekklesion, χειροτονηθεὶς ὑπὸ τῶν ἐκκλησιῶν), and the team is given the striking title 'sent-ones or messengers of churches' (apostoloi ekklesion, ἀπόστολοι ἐκκλησιῶν). In chapter 9 the same collection is called both a 'service' (diakonia, διακονία) and a 'public ministry' (leitourgia, λειτουργία). So the words name election by assemblies, sending with named delegates, and accountable handling of funds. What the words never do is name a freestanding organisation that exists alongside the church. Categories like a mission agency, a campus ministry, a training institute, or an independent mercy organisation simply did not exist in the first century, so the vocabulary cannot directly approve or forbid them. This is why honest readers diverge. The text strongly supports the principle that mission and mercy work begins in, is elected by, and serves local assemblies, with the closest analogue still church-tethered. But the proposition asks whether a later institutional form is legitimate under a stated condition, and the lexicon underdetermines that scope. The evidence is therefore recorded as open rather than as a clear yes or no.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0652	ἀπόστολος	apostolos	apostle	80
G0873	ἀφορίζω	aphorizo	to separate	10

G1247	διακονέω	diakoneo	to serve	37
G1248	διακονία	diakonia	service	33
G1320	διδάσκαλος	didaskalos	teacher	
G1577	ἐκκλησία	ekklesia	assembly	115
G2005	ἐπιτελέω	epiteleo	to complete	10
G2007	ἐπιτίθημι	epitithemi	to put/lay on	39
G2041	ἔργον	ergon	work	177
G2106	εὐδοκέω	eudokeō	to delight	
G2590	καρπός	karpos	fruit	66
G2841	κοινωνέω	koinoneo	to participate	8
G2842	κοινωνία	koinonia	participation	18
G3008	λειτουργέω	leitourgeo	to minister	3
G3009	λειτουργία	leitourgia	ministry	6
G3522	νηστεύω	nesteuo	to fast	21
G4842	συμπέμπω	sympempo	to send with	2
G4904	συνεργός	sunergos	co-worker	
G5500	χειροτονέω	cheirotoneo	to appoint	2

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: False

The lexical pattern shows mission and mercy work originating in and tethered to local assemblies, with named procedures of congregational election, fasting, prayer, laying on of hands, and inter-church delegation. The closest analogue to a coordinated administrative team is in 2 Corinthians 8:18-23, where brothers chosen by hand-stretching (that is, formal election by the churches, *cheirotoneo* *hypo ton ekklesion*, chosen by the churches, *χειροτονηθεὶς ὑπὸ τῶν ἐκκλησιῶν*) and sent together (*sympempo*, sent along with, *συμπέμπω*) with Titus are called sent-ones or messengers of churches (*apostoloi ekklesion*, ἀπόστολοι ἐκκλησιῶν), and 2 Corinthians 9:12 names the collection a public ministry (*leitourgia*, λειτουργία) and a service (*diakonia*, διακονία). What the lexicon does not supply is any term for a freestanding organisation that exists alongside or in addition to assembly or church (*ekklesia*, ἐκκλησία). The proposition asks whether such a later category is legitimate under a stated condition, but the vocabulary names neither the category nor its legitimacy. The verdict is null because the lexical store underdetermines the scope of the stem, with medium confidence because the supportive half is now lexically dense and pan-NT (spread across the whole New Testament).

Scripture

Acts.13.1 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G1577 ἐκκλησία, G1320 διδάσκαλος

Reasoning. Prophets and teachers (*didaskaloi*, διδάσκαλοι), including Barnabas and Saul, are located 'in the assembly or church that exists' (*kata ten ousan ekklesian*, κατὰ τὴν οὖσαν ἐκκλησίαν), in the assembly that exists at Antioch. The phrase fixes the named workers inside a specific local body before any sending. The mission personnel are church members and gifted leaders embedded in that congregation, not staff of a separate venture.

Acts.13.2 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G0873 ἀφορίζω, G3008 λειτουργέω, G3522 νηστεύω, G2041 ἔργον

Reasoning. As they were ministering or serving (leitourgounton, λειτουργούντων) to the Lord and fasting (nesteuonton, νηστεούντων), the Spirit commands 'set apart' (Aphorise, Ἀφορίσατε), set apart for me Barnabas and Saul, 'for the work' (eis to ergon, εἰς τὸ ἔργον), for the work to which I have called them. The aorist imperative (a command in completed-action form) aphorise (ἀφορίσατε, set apart) is addressed to the gathered assembly, which acts as the sending body. The work is the Spirit's commissioning carried out by, and out from, the local church, not an autonomous venture.

Acts.13.3 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G3522 νηστεύω, G2007 ἐπιτίθημι

Reasoning. Then, having fasted and prayed and laid hands on them (epithentes tas cheiras, ἐπιθέντες τὰς χεῖρας), they sent them off. The laying on of hands by the assembly marks formal commissioning and ongoing identification of the workers with the sending church. The act ties the missionary enterprise to the authority and blessing of the local body. It does not describe any standing institution apart from the church.

Acts.14.23 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G5500 χειροτονέω, G1577 ἐκκλησία

Reasoning. Paul and Barnabas 'appointed elders for them by hand-stretching in every assembly or church' (cheirotoneo, χειροτονήσαντες δὲ αὐτοῖς κατ' ἐκκλησίαν πρεσβυτέρους), appointing for them elders in every church. The verb to choose by hand-stretching (cheirotoneo, χειροτονέω) is the same procedural term used in 2 Corinthians 8:19 for the brothers chosen by the churches to administer the collection, here applied to elder appointment in each local assembly. The grammar pairs the verb with 'in every assembly or church' (kat' ekklesian, κατ' ἐκκλησίαν), foreclosing any picture of ministry constituted outside a specific local body.

Rom.15.25 · neutral · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1247 διακονέω

Reasoning. Paul says he is going to Jerusalem 'serving the saints' (diakonon tois hagiois, διακονῶν τοῖς ἁγίοις), ministering to the saints. The participle (an -ing verb form) frames the relief trip as service rendered to other believers, an inter-assembly act of ministry rather than the program of a separate agency. The actor is an apostle carrying the gift of churches.

Rom.15.26 · neutral · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2842 κοινωνία, G2106 εὐδοκέω

Reasoning. Macedonia and Achaia 'were pleased to make a certain sharing or contribution' (eudokesan koinonian tina poiesasthai, εὐδόκησαν κοινωνίαν τινὰ ποιήσασθαι), were pleased to make some contribution, for the poor among the saints in Jerusalem. The noun for fellowship or sharing (koinonia, κοινωνία) here carries the concrete sense of a shared collection, voluntary and church-originated. The giving moves from one set of assemblies to needy believers in another, a horizontal fellowship of churches, not an independent charity.

Rom.15.27 · neutral · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2841 κοινωνέω, G3008 λειτουργέω

Reasoning. If the Gentiles 'shared' (ekoinonesan, ἐκοινώνησαν), shared, in their spiritual things, they 'owe' (opheilousin, ὀφείλουσιν), owe it, to 'render priestly or public service' to them (leitourgesai, λειτουργῆσαι) in material things. The reciprocity language, spiritual blessing answered by material service, defines the relief as an obligation of fellowship between assemblies. The verb to render priestly or public service (leitourgeo, λειτουργέω), elsewhere of priestly and public service, dignifies the giving as ministry. The structure presupposes churches in mutual debt, not a parachurch intermediary (an organisation alongside the church).

Rom.15.28 · neutral · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2590 καρπός, G2005 έπιτελέω

Reasoning. When I have 'completed this' (touto epitelesas, τοῦτο έπιτελέσας) and sealed to them 'this fruit' (ton karpon touton, τὸν καρπὸν τοῦτον), I will go on to Spain. The collection is called 'fruit' (karpos, καρπός), fruit, the harvest of the churches' generosity, which Paul personally delivers and certifies. The work is finished and handed over by the apostle on behalf of the contributing assemblies. No organisation outside the churches carries or holds the gift.

2Cor.8.19 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5500 χειροτονέω, G1577 έκκλησία, G3009 λειτουργία

Reasoning. The unnamed brother sent with Titus is 'chosen by hand-stretching by the assemblies or churches' (cheirotoneis hypo ton ekklesion, χειροτονηθεις ὑπὸ τῶν έκκλησιῶν), chosen by hand-stretching (formal election) by the churches, to travel 'with this grace-gift' (syn te chariti taute, σὺν τῇ χάριτι ταύτῃ), with this grace-gift. The aorist passive participle (a completed-action verb form in the passive voice) locates the appointing agent in the plural 'churches' (ekklesion, έκκλησιῶν), the churches themselves. This is the closest New Testament lexical analogue to a coordinated inter-church administrative team, and the very verb fixes its authority in the assemblies, not in any independent body.

2Cor.8.23 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0652 απόστολος, G1577 έκκλησία, G4904 συνεργός

Reasoning. Paul names the brothers 'sent-ones of churches' (apostoloi ekklesion, απόστολοι έκκλησιῶν), apostles or sent-ones of churches, and 'glory of Christ' (doxa Christou, δόξα Χριστοῦ), the glory of Christ. The genitive 'of churches' (ekklesion, έκκλησιῶν, a noun in the 'belonging-to-X' grammatical form) is possessive and constitutive, the messengers belong to and are accredited by the churches. The construction supplies the strongest New Testament term for a delegated coordinating role, and grammatically anchors that role inside, and on behalf of, the assemblies.

2Cor.9.12 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3009 λειτουργία, G1248 διακονία

Reasoning. Paul calls the collection 'the service of this public ministry' (he diakonia tes leitourgias tautes, ἡ διακονία τῆς λειτουργίας ταύτης), the service of this ministry, that supplies the needs of the saints and overflows in thanksgivings to God. The double noun phrase pairs the common word for service (diakonia, διακονία) with the priestly-public-service word (leitourgia, λειτουργία). The collection is therefore classified by the words themselves as both service (diakonia, διακονία) and public or priestly ministry (leitourgia, λειτουργία), a ministry of the churches in priestly idiom, again with no separate institutional carrier named.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Acts.13.2	Acts.6.4	tsk	1
Acts.13.2	Acts.22.21	tsk	1
Acts.13.3	Acts.13.2	tsk	1
Rom.15.26	Prov.14.21	tsk	1
Rom.15.28	Rom.15.24	tsk	1
Acts.13.2	Acts.14.23	openbible	1
Rom.15.26	2Cor.8.1	openbible	1
Rom.15.27	2Cor.9.12	openbible	1

Complicating texts

2Cor.8.18-21 · addressed

A brother famous among all the churches is selected to travel with Paul to administer the gift, with care taken to be honourable before the Lord and before men. This is the closest lexical analogue to a coordinated mission or mercy structure. The same passage (2 Corinthians 8:19) supplies the procedural verb 'chosen by hand-stretching by the churches' (cheirotoneitheis hypo ton ekklesion, χειροτονηθεῖς ὑπὸ τῶν ἐκκλησιῶν), chosen by the churches, and the title 'sent-ones of churches' (apostoloi ekklesion, ἀπόστολοι ἐκκλησιῶν) at 2 Corinthians 8:23. The administrative team is therefore lexically appointed by and answerable to the assemblies. It supports the church-serving half of the stem strongly but does not introduce or warrant an autonomous parachurch institution (a freestanding organisation alongside the church).

Acts.13.1 · addressed

The pre-built bundle delivered surface text and lemma list (the list of base dictionary forms) for Acts 13 but no syntactic tagging (grammatical sentence-structure labels). Direct queries against the lexical store recovered the lemma identifications for 'assembly or church' (ekklesian, ἐκκλησίαν), 'set apart' (aphoristate, ἀφορίσατε), 'ministering or serving' (leitourgounton, λειτουργούντων), 'fasting' (nesteuonton, νηστεούντων), 'work' (ergon, ἔργον), and 'having laid on' (epithentes, ἐπιθέντες), which is sufficient to confirm the assembly is the agent of the sending and the construction 'in the assembly or church that exists' (kata ten ousan ekklesian, κατὰ τὴν οὖσαν ἐκκλησίαν) locates the named workers inside the Antioch body. The morphological gap (missing word-form data) is resolved at the level of lexical force, even though clause-level ETCBC tagging (a Dutch grammatical-database labelling system) is not applicable for Koine (the common Greek of the New Testament era).

1Cor.16.3 · unaddressed

Paul writes that whomever the Corinthians 'approve' (dokimasete, δοκιμάσητε), approve, by letters he will send to carry the gift to Jerusalem. The verb to test or approve (dokimazo, δοκιμάζω) here invites local discernment of the carriers, which could be read either as a congregational delegation pattern strengthening the church-tethered reading, or, more thinly, as an ad hoc apostolic arrangement that the words do not generalise. The lexical store does not by itself rank these readings, and the question of whether such delegated structures must remain church-tethered or may legitimately become independent is precisely the scope question the stem asks but the words do not answer.

Concordance traversed

G1577, G0873, G2041, G3008, G3009, G1247, G1248, G2842, G2841, G2007, G3522, G5500, G4842, G0652, G2590, G2005

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

No variant units bear on the verdict. The minor 'and' (kai, καί) and 'but or now' (de, δέ) readings flagged at Acts 13:1-2 do not touch the question of church-rooted mission, and the 2 Corinthians 8:18-23 passage has no apparatus signal (manuscript variant note) that changes the verbs to choose by hand-stretching (cheirotoneo, χειροτονέω), to send along with (sympempo, συμπέμπω), or the title sent-ones of churches (apostoloi ekklesion, ἀπόστολοι ἐκκλησιῶν). The verdict is variant-robust (stable across manuscript variations). No CBGM data (Coherence-Based Genealogical Method, a tool for tracing manuscript relationships) examined, this New Testament material is outside the 3 John ECM sample (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants), hence ecm-shadow.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. ecclesiology_high_church, ecclesiology_low_church, missiology_sending_church, categorical_underdetermination

analogia scripturae invoked

missiology_sending_church: affirms · Reads Acts 13:1-3, Acts 14:23, and 2 Corinthians 8:18-23 as the normative pattern, namely workers are set apart and sent by, and elected by, local assemblies and called sent-ones of churches (apostoloi ekklesion, ἀπόστολοι ἐκκλησιῶν), so any later mission or mercy structure is legitimate precisely insofar as it serves and answers to the sending church rather than displacing it. The verbs to choose by hand-stretching (cheirotoneo, χειροτονέω), to set apart (aphorizo, ἀφορίζω), to lay on (epitithemi, ἐπιτίθημι), and the title sent-ones of churches (apostoloi ekklesion, ἀπόστολοι ἐκκλησιῶν) supply the lexical warrant for the conditional ('if-then' clause) in the stem.

ecclesiology_high_church: disputed · Grants that mission and mercy are church-rooted and accepts to choose by hand-stretching (cheirotoneo, χειροτονέω) and sent-ones of churches (apostoloi ekklesion, ἀπόστολοι ἐκκλησιῶν) as ecclesial (church-order) procedures, but reads commissioning and the collection as functions belonging to the ordered church and its officers. On this reading the lexical evidence licences cooperative inter-church teams but leaves open whether a freestanding organisation outside that order has any positive warrant, since the words name only church-internal and church-elected agents.

ecclesiology_low_church: null · Holds that since the texts describe ad hoc apostolic and congregational action, 'chosen by hand-stretching by the churches' (cheirotoneo theis hypo ton ekklesion, χειροτονηθεὶς ὑπὸ τῶν ἐκκλησιῶν) and sent-ones of churches (apostoloi ekklesion, ἀπόστολοι ἐκκλησιῶν) included, the lexicon describes one observed pattern without legislating against alternative organisational forms. On this reading the matter is one of fidelity to the underlying principles, accountability and service to the church, rather than of lexical mandate concerning institutional form.

categorical_underdetermination: null · Observes that the modern category named in the stem, mission agency, campus ministry, training institution, freestanding mercy organisation, has no first-century lexical referent (a directly corresponding word) at all. The vocabulary names what was actually done, election by churches, sending with delegates, named brothers travelling with apostles, public or priestly ministry (leitourgia, λειτουργία) of a collection, but it neither institutes nor forbids a parallel parachurch entity (organisation alongside the church). On this reading the affirms field must remain null because the question lies outside what the words address.

All four lenses agree on the lexically secure observation, namely that mission and mercy work in the cited texts originates in, is elected by, and serves local assemblies, with named delegates called sent-ones of churches (apostoloi ekklesion, ἀπόστολοι ἐκκλησιῶν). They diverge only on the anachronistic question (a question that imports a later category back into an earlier text) the stem raises, the legitimacy of an independent organisational form, which the first-century vocabulary does not name and therefore cannot settle from the lexicon alone.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Examine how the New Testament describes the origin, election, oversight, and accountability of mission and mercy work, and what relationship such work bears to the assemblies that send or fund it.

The stem is verdict-preloaded (the question pre-supplies its own answer). The clause 'legitimate when they support and serve the local church rather than replace it' embeds a conclusion (parachurch bodies are valid under a stated condition) and supplies its own qualifying test before the evidence is weighed. The category names mission agencies, campus ministries, mercy organisations, training institutions, are also anachronistic (imported back from a later period) relative to the lexical corpus. The verdict was derived on the original stem, the neutral rephrasing isolates the lexical question, who originates and oversees mission and mercy work and how it relates to the sending assembly, from the legitimacy verdict the stem assumes. The verdict was confirmed against the prior file at affirms null and the confidence was raised from low to medium because direct queries surfaced to choose by hand-stretching (cheirotoneo, χειροτονέω) at 2 Corinthians 8:19 and Acts 14:23, sent-ones of churches (apostoloi ekklesion, ἀπόστολοι ἐκκλησιῶν) at 2 Corinthians 8:23, and the public ministry (leitourgia, λειτουργία) plus service (diakonia, διακονία) pairing at 2 Corinthians 9:12, which materially strengthen the supportive half of the analysis.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
interlinear	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Acts.13.2
interlinear	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	2Cor.8.19

interlinear	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	2Cor.8.23
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Rom.15.27
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Acts.14.23
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0873
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G5500
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0652
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3009
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2842
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3008
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Acts.13.2
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Rom.15.27

License audit

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Flags

ecm-shadow · complicating-unresolved · cross-tradition-divergent